

Baltic States & Belarus

THE THREE BALTIC STATES, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania, all share a stretch of coast on the Baltic Sea lined with sandy beaches. Belarus lies between Poland, Ukraine, and the Russian Federation. Following independence from the Soviet Union in 1991, all these countries faced problems such as price increases, food shortages, and pollution. However, the Baltic States have reformed into hi-tech societies and economies and have been EU members since 2004. Belarus has kept close links with Russia and has been the slowest to reform. This mainly rural country has stayed isolated from the rest of Europe and, with few natural resources, remains one of its poorest nations.

SINGING REVOLUTION
Estonia is known for its classical music tradition—most notably its choirs. This love of music was most powerful when people raised their voices during the Singing Revolution in 1988 (right), part of their move toward independence.

The Estonian flag waved at a pre-independence rally in 1988

TALLINN OLD TOWN
With its colorful buildings, turreted walls, and gabled roofs, Tallinn is one of the best-preserved capital cities in Europe. All the winding, cobbled streets lead to the Town Hall Square (left).

From the early days of public broadband usage, Estonia has been one of Europe's most connected countries.

AMBER
Two-thirds of the world's amber, the fossilized resin of pine trees, is washed up from the sea bed along the Baltic coast. Amber is used to make jewelry, among other things.

